that is the fact of the matter, why perpetuate the lie through textbooks and why accuse and malign someone innocent/not guilty?

The excuse of Covid-19 regarding the removal of the chapter on the Mughal court is really pathetic. The issue is: why provide so much space to the Mughals—all of three chapters—at the expense of contemporary ruling dynasties in southern, western and eastern India? The Mughals were never paramount rulers of India. A large number of dynasties, contemporary to the Mughals, ruled various parts of India. Also, before Akbar (1556-1605) and after Aurangzeb (1658-1707), the Mughals were nothing more than regional or small territory rulers. For just 151 years of dominance, historians have given far more space than can be justified. And why only the Mughal court, and not the courts of the Cholas, Pandyas, Marathas, Yadavas, Kakatiyas, the Vijayanagara empire and so many more?

BEFORE AKBAR AND AFTER AURANGZEB, THE MUGHALS WERE NOTHING MORE THAN REGIONAL RULERS. WHY THREE CHAPTERS?

Past textbooks resorted to negationism on a large scale. Atrocities on non-Muslims, destruction of Hindu temples, jaziya etc. by Muslim rulers are either completely ignored or, at best, mentioned in passing. The famous West Bengal circular on history-writing—"*shuddho-ashuddho*"—gave clear instructions that atrocities on Hindus and destruction of temples by Muslims were not to be written about. Similarly, when it comes to ancient India, the idea was to present it in as bad a light as possible; never mention the sciences, mathematics, astrophysics, political and legal ideas or democratic institutions that arose in that epoch.



Hindu-Muslim riots were mentioned selectively. The Gujarat riots of 2002 is an example. Why not mention that the first reported riot in Ahmedabad occurred in 1713 over the celebration of Holi? Why not talk about the Ahmedabad riots of 1967-70 and 1985, which killed thousands of people and often lasted six months and more?

History helps us relate the present to the past in intelligible ways. Our systems of governments, political ideas, religious beliefs, art, architecture, cultural practices, educational systems, customs and behavioural patterns are all products of the past; recent or remote. History also provides societies and individuals with a sense of anchoring, a dimension of longitudinal meanings. "Individuals, communities, societies could scarcely exist if all knowledge of the past is wiped out," wrote the British social historian Arthur Marwick. "A society without history...would be like an individual without memory." I have always been of the opinion that history is a great unifying force provided it is written with responsibility and care. We must remember that over 70 per cent of our students leave school by the time they reach secondary level. They carry with them all their life what they study from Class I-X—that is, a very tender age. In such a situation, we must always teach our children history that all or at least most historians agree with. All controversial issues should be reserved for higher studies. I appeal to historians that they not burden schoolchildren with anything more than simple, uncontroversial and undisputed history. Accusing each other is neither going to help the image of the country nor enhance unity among the people. We need to help our people learn to live with history, not be trapped in history. ■

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